

Tongpu (Cynthia) Zhao

Ph.D. Candidate in Finance · Guanghua School of Management, Peking University

zhaotongpu@stu.pku.edu.cn · (+86) 198-0021-1525

Research Interests

Primary Fields: Political Economy, Economic History, Public Economics

Topics: State Capacity, Bureaucracy, Law and Economics, Financial Regulation, Judicial Systems

Education

Peking University, Guanghua School of Management Beijing, China

Ph.D. in Finance (Advisors: Prof. Li-An Zhou & Prof. Ji Shen) Sep 2024 – Present (Exp. 2028)

University of International Business and Economics, Master in Finance 2022 – 2024

Southwestern University of Finance and Economics, B.Econ. in Insurance 2018 – 2022

Working Papers

1. **“Who Screens for the State? Recentralization and Local Control in Environmental Review”** (With Prof. Li-An Zhou)

Status: Draft available

Abstract: Examines a recentralization reform where environmental review authority shifted from county to city governments. We find that instead of strengthening capacity, this reform reorganized local protectionism. City governments created new, selective intermediary chains that retain low-visibility compliance problems, with mayoral turnover partially unraveling these patterns, demonstrating that recentralization often turns fragmented localism into a more coordinated but selective city-level form.

2. **“The Shadow Fiscal Financier: Insurance Capital, Regulatory Shocks, and Local Government Debt in China”** (Sole Author)

Status: Draft available. Accepted for presentation: 2026 ARIA Annual Meeting

Abstract: Identifies insurance capital as a critical “shadow financier” for local government debt. Using a **Granular Bartik IV** based on liability-side regulatory shocks, I find that insurer “yield hunger” significantly compresses LGFV credit spreads, linking financial deregulation to implicit government guarantees.

3. **“Accelerating Fragility: Climate Shocks, Information Contagion, and Systemic Risk in Opaque Insurance Markets”** (with T. Hao & C. Wu)

Status: Major Revision at Journal of Risk and Insurance

Work in Progress

1. **“Securing the Care Workforce: How Public Insurance Commitments Reshape Human Capital Pipelines”**

Status: Reject and Resubmit at Management Science

Abstract: Studies whether public institutional commitment can upgrade healthcare human capital by altering the risk structure of the career path. Exploiting China’s Long-Term Care Insurance (LTCI) pilot as a natural experiment, I use 2016–2022 Gaokao admission data to show that LTCI exposure significantly increases the competitiveness of nursing admissions. Mechanism analysis reveals this effect is driven by a re-organization of hiring structures—offering broader liquidity and clearer career ladders—rather than wage increases, suggesting public commitment can reallocate talent even when wage schedules are rigid.

Publications

- [1] Hao, T., Zhou, L., Hu, P., **Zhao, T.**, & Wang, P. (2025). “From Hedge to Risk: Nonlinear Effects of Climate Policy Uncertainty on Corporate Biodiversity Exposure.” *Energy Economics*, 108885.

- [2] Wanyan, R., **Zhao, T.**, Suo, L., & Lai, G. C. (2025). “Digital Transformation and Total Factor Productivity in Insurance Companies: A Catalyst or Inhibitor?” *The Geneva Papers on Risk and Insurance—Issues and Practice*, 50(1), 142–184. (Corresponding Author)
- [3] Wanyan, R., Sun, Y., Suo, L., & **Zhao, T.** (2025). “How Does Directors’ and Officers’ Liability Insurance Affect the Fulfilment of Social Responsibility by State-Owned Enterprises?” *The Geneva Papers on Risk and Insurance—Issues and Practice*, 1–27. (Corresponding Author)

Grants, Honors & Fellowships

- **Selected Participant**, Harvard-Yenching Institute & UTokyo Joint Advanced Program 2026
Theme: The Political Economy of China and its Role in the World
- **Fellow, Peking University Modern Japan Research Program** 2025–2026
- **Peking University Academic Innovation Award** 2024, 2025
- **China Development Research Scholarship** (DRC State Council) 2025
- **National Scholarship for Graduate Students** (Ministry of Education, Top 0.2%) 2023

Research Experience & Fellowships

Enterprise Research Institute, Development Research Center (DRC) of the State Council
Research Fellow Jan 2025 – Present

- Focus: Digital Economy, Enterprise Theory, Industrial Organization & Policy.

China Judicial Big Data Institute, The Supreme People’s Court of China
Research Fellow Oct 2024 – Present

- Constructed large-scale judicial datasets using **universe-level administrative case records**.

Peking University, Guanghua School of Management
Research Assistant to Prof. Li-An Zhou 2025 – Present

University of St. Gallen
Research Assistant to Prof. Martin Eling 2023

Teaching Experience

Peking University, Guanghua School of Management Beijing, China

- **Invited Tutor (Ph.D. Level, English):** Advanced Microeconomics (Fall 2025).
- **Teaching Assistant:** Chinese Economy & Graduate Micro. **Award:** Excellent TA (Top 10%).

Skills

Data Engineering: Web Scraping, OCR, NLP (Transformer), Regular Expression

Programming: Python, Stata, MATLAB, $\text{\LaTeX}$

Languages: Chinese (Native), English (Fluent, IELTS 7.5)

Certificates: Financial Risk Manager (FRM)

References

Prof. Li-An Zhou
Professor of Economics
Guanghua School of Management, PKU
zhoula@gsm.pku.edu.cn

Prof. Ji Shen
Professor of Finance
Guanghua School of Management, PKU
jishen@gsm.pku.edu.cn